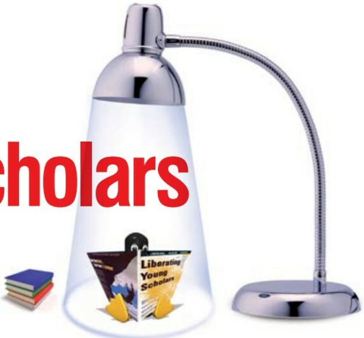
Liberating Young Scholars



In this and subsequent articles, we will try to explore FOSS-based software for education.

Today, computers are closely linked to education. While some schools use them as teaching aids, the more common uses of computers are for 'computer science', 'computer education', or 'computer literacy'. This is all very well except for a couple of aspects. One, sometimes computer activities are incorporated just for their own sake rather than as an analytical and problem-solving tool that extends the human reach. Two, and this is a subject close to our hearts, computer skills at home and school are imparted almost exclusively using proprietary tools. There are some exceptions, such as in the state of Kerala in southern India.

The purpose of education is purportedly to liberate. Paradoxically, it is computer education that needs to be liberated from closed mindsets.

Mindset Number One: Computer skills are about learning computer languages or tools—how often have you asked people about their skill-sets only to be told, 'Java', 'C++' or 'MS Office'? In case we have forgotten, computer skills are about solving real-world problems using computers and computer techniques, period! Knowing a particular language is just a small fraction of the gamut of possibilities computers offer.

Mindset Number Two: Train school students in all the important proprietary software suites and you have made them 'employable' with the requisite computer skills to fit into the world's largest back office—something that trade bodies want India to become as it comes of age. While some would believe this is a great role for India to play on the world stage, I feel that as a country with such vast potential we should set our sights higher.

We do not have a solution for the melting polar caps nor are we discounting the value of certain proprietary software in education. What we are saying, however, is that FOSS has a stellar role to play in revolutionising education in India in a very cost-effective manner. The liberating ideology and community orientation of FOSS is thrown in as a bonus. If you are the programming type, you can also modify the application to suit your requirements; this being one of the four freedoms that the GNU/GPL (as well as many other software licences) guarantees. It is time we gave FOSS a chance.

In this article we will look at how you can help our young scholars make the most of FOSS at home and at school. In the next part we will talk about how FOSS can help with enabling infrastructure on the education front. Our approach will be descriptive enumeration giving pointers for further exploration rather than a detailed review. That way, the fun of further exploration remains all yours! We are going to stick to GNU/Linux though, with no offence to Open Solaris and BSD fans.

The money is not funny!

If you are still on the fence about adopting FOSS, try this story for a fence ripper. At the time of writing this, the Maharashtra State Government has signed (away?) an MoU with a proprietary software giant for ICT deployment and training in its schools. [You can find pointers to this story in the References section. The Bangalore Student Edition of The Times of India dated August 25, 2009 also carries the story.] According to the report, this has an impact on 68,000 government schools with 300,000 teachers and 8 million